thing gives me a sheer rush of adrenaline and power. *What happens if I bowl short?* I ask myself. I might be able to even rush these guys, scare them a bit. I run in the same way towards the next senior player and, doing my best impression of what I imagine scary fast bowlers do, muscle the ball into the middle of the pitch as if it is a trampoline. It veers short of a length and hits the next batter on the head. He walks away rattled. I apologise and turn around, confused and giddy. With great power comes great responsibility, I do not think to myself then but should have.

I come back the next day praying that I hadn't imagined this, or that the speed and the way the ball has suddenly been blessed with a new energy isn't a strange anomaly, a one-night-only experience. But it is still there. It is part of my muscle memory now, the feel, the rhythm and the speed. They are not all wicket-taking balls – there are many wides, balls that fly off the pitch one side and then the other the following ball. I bowl more than four wides an over, frantically running in as I try to control this newfound speed. But in amongst it, I am managing to find balls that visibly shock players.

Martin van Jaarsveld is a travelling pro. He faces me first ball of a game, and as I am at my mark, my captain at mid-off says, 'Bounce him first ball; he won't be expecting it to be as quick as it will be.' I nod, take a deep breath and do what he says. When the ball leaves my hand, I lose sight of it for a second, before looking back up to see his body language implode while the ball is in flight, as if he is a boxer who had his gloves by his side prepared for a mismatch and then suddenly is trying to raise them in fright. He gloves it straight to the captain. I get other pros out too, including Roger Harper who nicks off a more classical delivery. Then Australian Brad Hodge, a serious scalp, fending a wayward beamer off his face with his gloves, who turns to me to say, 'Fuck off, you little prick,' before I bowl him. It is the kind of relationship with Australians that I will one day cultivate for fun. It is in these moments where I start to feel that if I can do this to these guys, maybe I can do it to anyone.

John Stanworth, the academy director, calls me up and gets me into play for Lancashire under-17s. I don't mention that I have been for trials before, at 12 and 14, and got nowhere near. I feel like someone else now. Kyle Hogg and Saj Mahmood are both a similar age to me and, rounded up from our different universes, all three of us can bowl much quicker than anyone else. As we progress into the Lancashire team, each one of us fuelling the